From that point on, the conflict in Gaza was a war in search of an objective. Or perhaps more accurately, it was an open-ended conflict tied to the ever-more difficult political objective of sustaining an unsustainable status quo.

In a brief statement announcing the start of the ground invasion, Netanyahu said the troops had been ordered “to strike at the terrorist tunnels from the Gaza Strip into Israeli territory.” Officials said the fighting would continue until the passages were destroyed, a process that should take “two or three days.” The tunnels were not, strictly speaking, a new weapon: Hamas had used them before, as far back as 2006, when the militants who captured Gilad Shalit used an underground passage to sneak across the border and then spirit him back into Gaza. In the summer of 2014 they were upgraded to an “existential threat”, as the head of the southern command told reporters; *Yediot Aharonot* warned that Hamas planned to sneak a force of 200 gunmen into Israel and seize control of a kibbutz on Rosh Hashanah, the Jewish new year.

Hyperbole aside, they were a real threat, a point that was underscored on 29 July, when Hamas killed five Israeli soldiers in a tunnel raid. The gunmen filmed it on a head-mounted camera; the eerie footage, posted on YouTube, shows them emerging from the passage and hiking through the desert before they open fire on an army post.

The Israeli government had known about this threat for years, though, and did nothing about it. The proposed Egyptian ceasefire, which Netanyahu eagerly accepted, would have left the tunnels intact—an existential threat with which, apparently, the prime minister was content to live. “They were a threat even before, but it’s not always the case that if we have some threats we decide to go immediately to a big ground operation in order to neutralize it,” Yuval Steinitz, the intelligence minister, tried unconvincingly to explain.

The military played its assigned role, targeting the rockets, then the tunnels. But rockets can be rebuilt, and tunnels re-dug. So in late July, with the Palestinian death toll already above 1,000, the rationale for war shifted again. Steinitz briefed foreign reporters, telling them that the war would only end once the international community agreed to “disarm” Hamas. “If we want a real comprehensive solution, that will bring not just an end to the current round of violence, but real relief for people on both sides of the fence: …you have to demilitarize Gaza, as it was supposed to be,” he said.